

DISRUPT THE FUTURE!

**HERE'S LOOKING FORWARD TO 10 DISRUPTIONS WE THINK WILL DEFINE
THE FUTURE WORLD WE WILL FIND OURSELVES LIVING IN**

BY ROBERT SOVEREIGN-SMITH

As we said at the beginning of this cover story, predicting the future is a slippery slope. We could have played it safe and gone with the standard story of what you can expect to see in 2016, but we'd probably fall asleep writing it, and you'd definitely fall asleep reading it. Instead, we've tried to look more long term. Some of the stuff we talk about here might only be achieved decades from now, whilst some others could happen in the next three to five years.

Some have already happened, or rather, have already happened elsewhere in the world and are still happening in India. To paraphrase a popular Facebook and WhatsApp forwarded message: Think about the world's largest taxi company – Uber; it owns no taxis. You find accommodation on Airbnb, even though it owns no real estate. The biggest retailer, Alibaba, has no inventory of its own. The biggest media owners are Facebook and YouTube, and neither creates any of that media. Netflix is the world's biggest movie house, and it owns no cinemas... and the two companies making the most money from selling software – Apple and Google – don't actually write the apps that earn them all that money!

What's important to understand, before we start with our own list, is that disruptions are not necessarily as simple

as they were before. The goal for the disruptor has traditionally been to carve a niche for themselves, and to do some new feature, or serve some new need well. Then, when everyone else realises that they really need that too, it starts doing everything else better.

Take the digital camera as an example: at first they were poor quality, they were low-res, they ate up batteries and they were terrible for anyone even remotely serious about photography. They did, however, cut out the need for film developing, and allowed people to click an unlimited amount of pictures, and to see what they'd clicked almost immediately. Eventually as storage prices fell, sensors got better, and the world moved to digital data storage, it became a no-brainer to buy a digital camera. This is a linear path the disruptor took. At least the target audience was the same, and both devices were still cameras. Kodak could have invested heavily in digital camera technologies early on to save itself. At least in theory.

Sometimes, however, the invading disruptor comes from such unexpected sources that there's nothing that could have been done. Take the example of GPS companies such as Garmin and TomTom and the likes. Their business model seemed sound. They targeted vehicles, and obviously everyone wanted directions in their vehicle. They would subsidise

the hardware cost by charging for map updates, and software updates.

However, when smartphones started getting GPS sensors just as good as the ones in these devices, it was but an obvious step for Google to put Google Maps on to the phones. Google started a navigation service, which spoke out directions just as your GPS did. The real disruption was caused by the maps always being up to date as they were stored on Google's servers. Plus, the service was free – all you paid was for data, which you were doing anyway.

Google claims it was not targeting GPS companies at all, and only wanted to offer the best experience for phone users. We believe them, because it's one of the most important aspects of a smartphone these days.

If you think of the GPS companies as stallions running a race, Google came along and accidentally dug a huge trench in their path. Perhaps Google is being honest when they say they didn't mean for all the stallions to fall into the trench and break their legs. However, what Google did next was akin to pulling out the shotgun and putting the injured stallions out of their misery – Google allowed users to download map packs onto their phones, so that even data connectivity wasn't needed when outside. RIP GPS guys, you will be forgotten, sadly.